

For Norway, FIFA World Cup 2026 marks the end of a 28-year wait. For Erling Haaland, it is the fulfilment of a childhood dream. The striker reflects on making history, following his father's footsteps and Norway's ambitions on football's biggest stage.

How excited are you to be part of this World Cup?

I just cannot express my excitement! It's such a big thing. I have never experienced it. When Norway played in the World Cup (1998), I wasn't even born. In fact, we last played in a major football

most goals (16) in the qualifiers to make it happen!

Well, it was a team effort, and my teammates helped me be there to score. It is really amazing to be part of the squad that made history and qualified for the biggest stage.

Personally, it should be an even bigger celebration since you will be emulating your father, Alf-Inge, by playing in a FIFA World Cup in the United States of America.

Yeah, that's so satisfying and, at the same time, so challenging! Dad always shared memories of playing in a World Cup, how big it was for him and his countrymen, etc. Now,

could not have. It's so exciting...

Norway is in a tough Group I with France, Senegal and Iraq. How confident are you of qualifying from this group?

See, this is impossible to predict in a World Cup. Yes, we have three nations with great footballing histories. We are trying to write ours as well.

And in the World Cup, it might sound clichéd, but the fact remains that every match will be tough. We have prepared to be at the best of our physical, mental and tactical abilities during that phase, and that's all for now.

« It is a dream-come-true moment for me »

ERLING HAALAND

tournament at Euro 2000, and I was not born then either! So, it is going to be the first time I shall be enjoying a World Cup with my countrymen, and that is huge. When I started playing professional football, it was a dream to see my country participate in a FIFA World Cup. Now, it is a dream-come-true moment for me.

Not only that, but you also played a significant part by scoring the

when the tournament ends, I shall be sharing my journey with him with the same excitement.

Will there be comparisons?

No comparisons, absolutely! It is all about celebration and pure joy. The fact that we shall be playing in the World Cup after 28 years is already the biggest thing to have happened in our football history. Kids in Norway will have memories to share when they grow up, something I

The last match of your group is already being hyped as a clash between Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland. Your thoughts?

Football is played 11 vs 11, never one versus one. It is a team game. Norway will play against French football, which is going through a golden period. They were the champions in 2018 and came so close to retaining the title in 2022. Kylian is, as everybody knows, a superb footballer. But he will need



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